

NYC's \$4 Million Restroom Pilot Tests Relief for Businesses

By Yufei Chen

New York City is rolling out 17 free modular public restrooms, including one at Cooper Square, in a \$4 million experiment that could provide some relief to restaurants and retailers that have become de facto bathroom providers in neighborhoods short on public facilities.

The one-year pilot will test whether a private startup can install and operate public bathrooms faster and more cheaply than traditional construction — and whether adding even a small number of facilities can ease the steady stream of people turning to nearby businesses when nature calls.

The New York City Economic Development Corporation selected Washington-based Throne Labs in June after a competitive bidding process to produce, install, operate and maintain the units. Installation began this month. The contract averages about \$235,000 per location, though that figure covers service and maintenance during the pilot and is not simply the purchase price of each bathroom.

New York has nearly 1,000 public restrooms, roughly 70% of them in parks, according to NYCEDC. The pilot will therefore add only a small number of facilities. But in Cooper Square, its success may be measured partly by whether fewer people must ask local businesses for a basic service those businesses were never designed to provide.

The Cooper Square unit will be one of four in Manhattan. Each unit will be free and open daily from 7 a.m. to 10 p.m. The self-contained bathrooms include a flushing toilet, running-water sink, climate control and baby-changing station, and require no connection to existing water, sewer or power infrastructure. Users can enter by text message, QR code, the Throne app or tap cards distributed by community organizations.

Local workers said the need is already visible.

Angelos Delakas, who runs Cooper Square News Corp. near the Astor Place subway entrance, said at least one person asks him for directions to a restroom each day, with as many as four inquiries on busier days. His newsstand has no restroom to offer, so he directs people to nearby stores.



Photo caption: *Cooper Square News Corp. sits near the Astor Place subway entrance. Angelos Delakas, who runs the newsstand, said between one and four people ask him for restroom directions each day. Photo by Yufei Chen.*

Carly, a restaurant owner near Cooper Square, said three to seven noncustomers ask to use her restroom on a typical night. She generally lets them in but sometimes refuses when she has safety concerns. She was skeptical that one new public bathroom would eliminate the requests.

Sammy, an employee at MUJI near Cooper Square, said restroom questions from passersby are common every day. He said a public unit would help businesses throughout the neighborhood, particularly around St. Marks Place, where heavy foot traffic and bars create steady demand.

Not every worker was unreservedly supportive. Makaila, a cafe employee nearby, said people ask her for restroom directions about four times a week. She said the planned unit could be useful but worried that drug use or crime inside could create new problems. She usually directs people to the restroom at Wegmans rather than an existing street facility.

Throne Labs will be responsible for cleaning and maintaining the bathrooms and will use sensors and real-time user feedback to monitor conditions. The company says its units have maintained more than 90% uptime across 1.7 million visits in other cities.

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